Youth Political Participation and Democracy in Europe

A Comparative Analysis of Young Adults and Older Adults Using European Social Survey Round 11

Project Report

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Abstract

This project examines the differences between young adults (18-29) and adults (30+), in terms of political involvement, voting, trust in politicians, direct political engagement, and online political involvement. The project is based on the European Social Survey (ESS) Round 11 integrated dataset, utilising data cleaning, descriptive statistical analysis, SQL queries, Python calculations and Power BI visualisation.

The data set originally has 50,116 records of the respondents. Out of these, 48,659 are in the two age groups which are chosen for the main comparison. The weighted descriptive results show that youth show lower levels of interest in politics or voting compared to older people, and higher levels of online political activity. Young adults are also less likely to have direct contact with politicians. There are also relatively low levels of trust in politicians in both groups, with a slightly higher weighted mean amongst young adults.

The project illustrates the application of quantitative data analysis to analyse questions of interest to political science and democratic participation and public policy. The results are descriptive and should not be viewed as evidence that age makes a difference in political engagement.

1. Introduction

Political participation is a key element of democratic representation and civic involvement. Learning about the nature of political behaviour by age can contribute to the debate of democratic inclusion, political institutions and citizen engagement. Voting is not the only form of political participation.

It encompasses an interest in political matters and communication with elected officials and involvement via the Internet. Trust in politicians also offers a measure of the attitudes towards political institutions. The aim of this project is to analyze some indicators of political behavior among young and older adults based on a survey conducted by the European Social Survey.

It brings together data preparation, quantitative analysis and visualisation to discover differences between the two groups.

2. Research Objectives

The project has five objectives:

1. Compare political interest among young adults aged 18–29 and adults aged 30 and above.
2. Examine differences in reported voting behaviour, including respondents who were not eligible to vote.
3. Compare the proportions of respondents who reported contacting a politician.
4. Examine differences in online political activity.
5. Compare average trust in politicians between the two age groups.

3. Data Source and Scope

The project uses the European Social Survey Round 11 Integrated Dataset, Edition 4.2, covering the 2023/24 survey period.

The uploaded dataset contains 50,116 respondent records and includes variables relating to country, age, gender, educational attainment, political interest, trust in politicians, voting, contacting politicians, online political activity and survey weights.

Respondents were divided into two age groups:

- **Young adults:** 18–29 years
- **Older adults:** 30 years and above

The cleaned dataset contains 6,393 young adults and 42,266 older adults, giving a total of 48,659 respondents in the main age-group comparison. The remaining 1,457 records were not assigned to either group because they fell outside the defined analysis categories or lacked a usable age classification.

The analysis pools respondents from the countries represented in the dataset. It does not assume

4. Data Preparation and Methodology

4.1 Data Cleaning

The original dataset was retained separately from the cleaned analytical dataset. Relevant variables were organised into a structured table, including country, respondent identifier, age, age group, gender, education, political interest, trust in politicians, voting, contacting politicians, online political activity and the analysis-weight variable.

The data preparation process involved:

- Selecting variables relevant to the research objectives.
- Creating age groups from respondents' ages.
- Converting coded survey responses into readable categories.
- Treating special response codes and missing answers as missing where appropriate.
- Checking data types, missing values, age-group counts and respondent identifiers.
- Retaining respondents with missing answers to individual questions rather than excluding them from every analysis.

Missing responses were handled separately for each outcome. Consequently, the valid sample size differs across the political-interest, voting, trust, contacting-politicians and online-activity analyses.

4.2 Analytical Approach

Categorical outcomes were analysed by calculating the percentage distribution of valid responses within each age group. The calculations were repeated using the dataset's Analysis_Weight variable to produce weighted descriptive percentages.

Trust in politicians was measured on a scale from 0 to 10. Weighted mean trust scores were calculated for respondents with valid trust scores.

The analysis used the following tools:

- **Microsoft Excel:** Data organisation, cleaning, variable documentation and preliminary summaries.
- **SQL:** Queries for respondent counts, age-group comparisons, response distributions and descriptive statistics.
- **Python:** Data validation, grouped summaries and weighted calculations using Pandas and NumPy.
- **Matplotlib and Seaborn:** Statistical visualisation.
- **Microsoft Power BI:** Dashboard development and comparison of political participation indicators.

The findings presented below use weighted descriptive summaries. They are not tests of statistical significance and do not establish causal relationships.

5. Key Findings

5.1 Political Interest

Political interest differed between young adults and older adults.

Political interest	Young adults (18–29)	Older adults (30+)
Hardly interested	40.35%	33.45%

Not at all interested	22.91%	19.18%
Quite interested	26.84%	33.05%
Very interested	9.90%	14.32%

Young adults had larger proportions in the hardly interested and not at all interested categories. Older adults had larger proportions in the quite interested and very interested categories.

These results indicate that reported political interest was lower among young adults in the analysed sample. However, political interest alone does not determine whether an individual participates in political activities.

5.2 Voting Behaviour

Reported voting behaviour also differed between the two age groups.

Voting response	**Young adults (18–29)**	**Older adults (30+)**
Yes	49.29%	75.24%
No	30.20%	20.75%
Not eligible	20.51%	4.01%

The weighted proportion reporting that they voted in the last national election was higher among older adults than young adults. Young adults also had a substantially higher proportion reporting that they were not eligible to vote.

Eligibility is important when interpreting these results. The percentages describe the distribution of reported responses, including ineligible respondents; they should not be interpreted as turnout rates among eligible voters.

5.3 Trust in Politicians

Trust in politicians was measured on a scale ranging from 0 to 10.

Measure	**Young adults (18–29)**	**Older adults (30+)**

Weighted mean trust score	3.48	3.30
Valid responses	6,250	41,694

Young adults had a slightly higher weighted mean trust score than older adults. However, both averages were relatively low on the 0–10 scale. The difference is modest and should not be overstated.

5.4 Contacting Politicians

The weighted proportions reporting that they contacted a politician were:

Response	Young adults (18–29)	Older adults (30+)
Yes	8.85%	14.98%
No	91.15%	85.02%

Older adults were more likely to report contacting a politician. Direct contact with politicians was relatively uncommon in both age groups, particularly among young adults.

This measure captures one form of political participation and does not represent every way in which respondents may engage with politics.

5.5 Online Political Activity

Online political activity showed a different pattern from voting and direct contact.

Response	Young adults (18–29)	Older adults (30+)
Yes	24.06%	14.87%
No	75.94%	85.13%

Young adults were more likely than older adults to report online political activity. This finding suggests that participation differs according to the form of engagement being measured.

Online activity should be considered alongside conventional indicators such as voting and contacting politicians when examining political participation among younger citizens.

6. Discussion

The results show that the age and political behaviour relationship is different across different types of political behaviour.

Young adults had lower levels of political interest and voting participation than older adults. They were also less likely to have contacted politicians. Young adults were more likely to be involved in online political activity, however, than were older adults. Young adults had a slightly higher weighted mean score than the other group regarding average trust in politicians, but both groups had relatively low levels of trust.

The patterns underscore the need to consider political participation from several perspectives. Voting and traditional contact with representatives does not tell the full story about political participation. The online participation offers a supplement to understanding the engagement of younger citizens in politics.

The analysis does not attempt to explain the reason behind the differences. Factors that may also be relevant include education, national context, eligibility for the election, and other social conditions. These relationships would need to be explored further.

7. Limitations

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the results.

Descriptive analysis: The project identifies patterns and differences but does not establish causation or test whether the differences are statistically significant.

Survey weights: The weighted summaries use the dataset's Analysis_Weight variable. The results should be interpreted in accordance with the definition of that weight in the official ESS documentation. The weighting procedure does not, by itself, account for every aspect of the survey design.

Missing responses: Valid-response sample sizes differ across outcomes because some respondents did not provide usable answers to every question.

Unequal group sizes: The dataset contains substantially more respondents aged 30 and above than respondents aged 18–29.

Cross-country variation: The main analysis pools respondents across participating countries. It does not fully investigate differences in national political systems, electoral rules or country-specific participation patterns.

Measurement scope: The selected variables represent specific indicators of political engagement. They do not capture every form of civic or political participation.

8. Conclusion

This project involved analysing data from the European Social Survey Round 11 to compare the levels of political interest, the way young adults (18-29) and adults (30+) vote, levels of trust in politicians, direct contact with politicians and online political activity.

The weighted descriptive results suggest that younger adults had less political interest, voted less, and had less direct interaction with politicians than older adults. They also were more likely to report online political activity at the same time. Levels of trust in politicians were relatively low in both groups, and slightly higher in the weighted mean among the young adults.

The project illustrates how to use data cleaning, variable documentation, SQL queries and Python analysis and Power BI visualisation to answer a research question useful in political science and public policy.

Future studies might explore intercountry differences, the effect of the ESS design and determine if differences in education or other characteristics of the respondent are linked to political participation. These extensions would further enable an understanding of these patterns found in this project in greater detail.

9. Tools and Technologies

- **Microsoft Excel:** Data organisation, cleaning, variable documentation and preliminary summaries.

- **SQL:** Respondent counts, grouped response distributions and descriptive queries.
- **Python:** Data validation and weighted summaries using Pandas and NumPy.
- **Matplotlib and Seaborn:** Statistical charts and visualisations.
- **Microsoft Power BI:** Dashboard development and visual comparison of political engagement by age group.

10. Data Reference

European Social Survey (ESS). *Round 11 Integrated Dataset, Edition 4.2 (2023/24)*. European Social Survey Data Portal: https://www.europeansocialsurvey.org/data-portal

The official ESS documentation should be consulted for the complete dataset citation and the precise definitions of the variables and analysis weight used in this project.